



multitasking, app launches, and general navigation efficiently. Gaming performance is satisfactory, with titles like Genshin Impact and PUBG Mobile running well. The phone adopts a conservative performance strategy to manage thermals effectively, throttling to 91 per cent of its peak performance during a 15-minute CPU Throttling Test.

The Xiaomi 14 Civi ships with Android 14, overlaid with Xiaomi's HyperOS. Xiaomi has promised three years of OS updates and four years of security updates, which, while not as extensive as those offered by Samsung or Google, are respectable. HyperOS is feature-rich with extensive customization options and some AI features, but it includes considerable bloatware, placing it behind NothingOS and Stock Android in terms of pre-installed apps.

CAMERAS

The camera system on the Xiaomi 14 Civi has received a significant upgrade, incorporating Leica algorithms for enhanced image processing. The main camera is a 50MP Summilux lens, accompanied by a 50MP 2x telephoto lens and a 12MP ultrawide camera. Up front, there's a dual camera setup with a 32MP main selfie camera and a 32MP ultrawide camera.

The main and ultrawide cameras deliver good detail and low noise

levels even in low light. However, the Leica colour science tends to push for exaggerated tones and deeper shadows, creating an oil painting-like effect that some might find overly saturated. The ultrawide shots do have crushed shadows in tricky lighting though, so the dynamic range is as strong on this lens.

Portrait shots, while vibrant, can smooth out textures more than some might prefer. In fact, I found portraits to be very inconsistent on the phone; some looked exceptional with the contrast-heavy look while some just looked overexposed and excessively smoothed out. There were times when the issue of overexposing shots even cropped up in non-portrait images on the primary camera, so Xiaomi could work on the HDR abilities of the phone. I hope this can be smoothed over with an OTA update.

Despite this, the cameras on the Xiaomi 14 Civi are some of the best in the segment. It wins in terms of detail retention, low light performance, and portrait bokeh over phones such as the OnePlus 12R and Nothing Phone (2). The Cinematic Vision mode offers various video settings, including a wide-screen aspect ratio and subject tracking. The video quality is commendable, especially with the option to apply Leica filters across modes.

BATTERY LIFE

The Xiaomi 14 Civi's 4700mAh battery pales in comparison to the 5,500 mAh battery on the OnePlus 12R. While it comfortably lasts through a day of moderate use, I felt a lot more battery anxiety on this phone than I ever did with the OnePlus 12R and even the Nothing Phone (2). In our 4K video loop test, the Xiaomi 14 Civi only lasted 798 minutes, which is a little over 13 hours.

The 67W fast charging capability is also not impressive. It fully charges the battery in about 47 minutes, which is quite mediocre.

VERDICT

The Xiaomi 14 Civi is a pretty 'Leica'able smartphone that combines a unique design, an impressive display, solid performance, and versatile camera capabilities to bring you a flagship-akin experience at a relatively affordable price. Its lightweight and slim profile make it an attractive option for those who prioritise aesthetics and ergonomics.

The cameras, while inconsistent at times, are some of the best you can find in this price range with the typical Leica look that sets it apart from competitors. However, it may not be the best choice for power users seeking a phone with a long battery life, as the device tends to underperform in this regard when compared to popular options such as the OnePlus 12R. Additionally, those who prefer a cleaner UI may be better off considering the Nothing Phone (2) or the Pixel 8a.

—Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Snapdragon 8s Gen 3 | GPU: Adreno 735 | RAM: 8/12 GB LPDDR5X | Storage: 256/512 GB UFS 4.0 | OS: Android 14, HyperOS | Display: 6.55" LTPO AMOLED, 68B colours, 1236 x 2750 pixels | Refresh rate: 120 Hz | Display protection: Corning Gorilla Glass Victus 2 | Camera: 50 MP + 50 MP + 12 MP (Leica Lenses) | Selfie: 32 MP + 32 MP | Battery capacity: 4,700 mAh | Charging: 67 W | Colours: Cruise Blue, Matcha Green, Shadow Black | Weight: 177.6 g

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